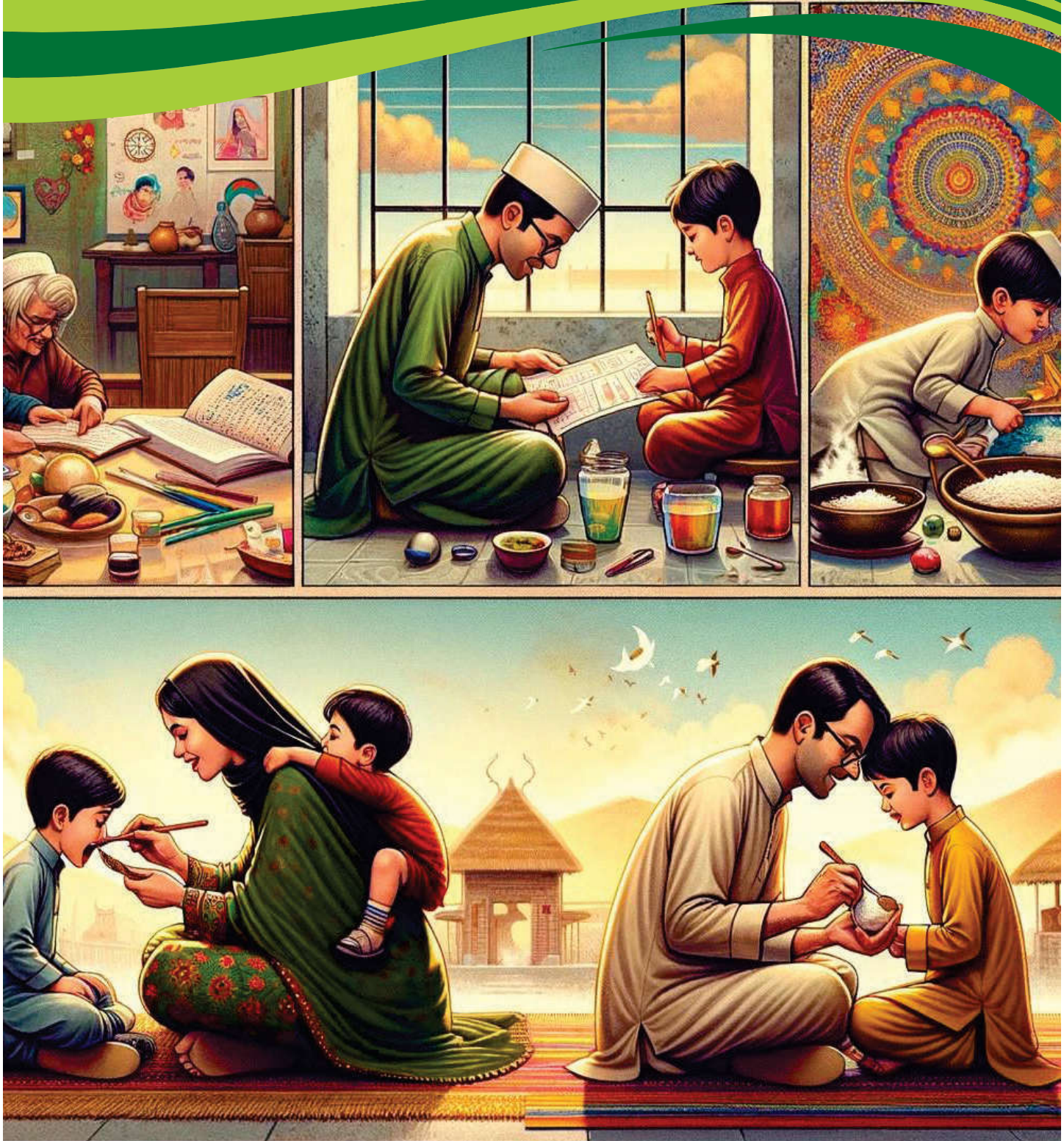


Module 1: Nurturing our Youth



Background

Parents often see their children as investments. This is not the case only in Pakistan. The term parental investment into children refers to the resources, like time and money, spent by parents on their children, while raising them. Just as with any other investment, they consider managing their children's risks and opportunities in life as their responsibility. Every parent wants to give the best to their children, so that they grow into well-nourished, healthy adults. In addition to time and money, parents also provide emotional, moral, psychological, and social support to the child. Moreover, prioritizing children, by devoting one's time and resources to them, is considered a fundamental societal value. Also, across the globe, investing in children denotes a safeguard; both for the future of communities, overall, and individual families, specifically.

Childhood presents an unparalleled window of opportunity. The science of childhood development shows that even brief periods of deprivation in the early years can permanently impact a child's future abilities, subsequently influencing a nation's future potential. It is, therefore, imperative that all children have adequate access to core facilities, such as health, education, and proper nutrition. Ensuring these essentials will pave the way for more equitable opportunities in securing higher-paying jobs in the future and in enhancing their overall productivity.

The benefits derived from investing in children extend beyond the recipients themselves. Societies that are healthier and better educated yield benefits for everyone. Although there might be a time lag between the initial investments and the complete realization of their benefits to the society and the economy, the rewards can be substantial and perpetual. However, due to the potential inability of the poorest and most vulnerable segments of society to make optimal investments in their children, there is a compelling argument for public fund allocations in social sectors concerning children, particularly targeting those in dire need.

Activity 1.1: Investing In Our Youth (Time: 20 minutes)

Objectives. This activity will help parents reflect upon what they mean by investing in their child and how their parents have invested in them in terms of money, emotions, and time.

Resources. A flashcard saying: “How much have you invested in your child? Socially, Financially, and Emotionally?”

Activity steps and instructions.

- 1) The Facilitator will
 - request the participants to sit in a circle
 - show them the flashcard and request them to reflect on the question written on it for five minutes
- 2) After five minutes, ask them to share their thoughts on the question: What is the driving factor behind parents investing in their children? (Tell them that their responses can overlap and that there is no right or wrong perspective). Is it because
 - a. they want their children to become overall better human beings through their parenting style? (Personal accomplishment for parents)
 - b. of societal pressure, that they want their children to become high achievers, thereby potentially earning higher income, resulting in better quality of life for the next generation? (Social class status)
 - c. they hope to receive Returns On Investments (ROI) during their own old age? (Payback time)
 - d. they believe that children are a gift from God and should, therefore, be cherished and nurtured? (Religious perspective)

Learning outcomes. The parents will be able to reflect on the ways in which they have invested in their children and why. With the best of intentions, parents sometimes nurture their children in a manner that is not necessarily in their children’s best interest; where the actions could be causing more harm than good.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Discuss with the parents that their role in fostering the comprehensive development of their children is pivotal and crucial, necessitating a direct involvement in their growth and development. Make sure that the parents understand that investment here is not solely a matter of financial commitment but it also involves cultivating a meaningful and positive parent-child relationship. Tell the parents that they can do the following things to make sure that they spend enough quality time with their children:

- a. Establish a rule to have one family meal together each day, without phones, allowing everyone to talk and share their daily activities.
- b. Participate in your child's school and extracurricular activities to show your support and involvement.
- c. Be present and emotionally supportive when your child is going through a difficult phase.
- d. Always listen to your child's perspective before reacting in social or any other situations.
- e. Communicate your limitations clearly.
- f. Strive to fulfill your commitments.
- g. Invest in your child's social, mental, and physical well-being.

Free Video Link. This video can be played after or during the session:

[ps://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VWNH99t9Ijg](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VWNH99t9Ijg)

Positive Youth Development (PYD) models.

The concept of Positive Youth Development (PYD) models is centered on the idea that all young people have the potential to develop into healthy, successful, and flourishing individuals in society. This approach contrasts with the deficit-based models, which focus on correcting problems and preventing negative outcomes.

A significant amount of research in developmental psychology underpins PYD, which demonstrates that such an approach can lead to better educational outcomes, lower involvement in risky behaviors, and improved social skills.

Core dimensions of the PYD models. The PYD models emphasize five core dimensions, known as the "5Cs":

1. **Competence.** Pakistani youth can be encouraged to excel in areas like academia and sports through national initiatives, such as those offered by the Pakistan Educational Foundation or the local youth sports clubs, which promote skills that are celebrated and supported within the community.
2. **Confidence.** Programs like the Youth Parliament of Pakistan give young individuals a platform to voice their opinions and develop leadership skills, thereby boosting their confidence and self-efficacy.
3. **Connection.** Institutions like the Higher Education Commission of Pakistan can foster connections, by facilitating mentorship programs linking students with professionals. Also, family-oriented community events can provide ample opportunities to strengthen social bonds.
4. **Character.** Service-learning opportunities can be integrated into the educational curriculums, and organizations like the Pakistan Red Crescent Society can offer avenues for young people to get involved in community service, which can help promote integrity and build moral character.



5. ***Caring.*** Initiatives like community-based health programs can involve youth by seeking their voluntary support in local health drives, thereby nurturing a sense of caring and empathy towards others.

When young people develop these five characteristics, they are more likely to be well-rounded and to engage positively with their communities. The PYD framework also acknowledges that the "6th C", that of contribution (youth making a meaningful contribution to their communities), emerges when the 5Cs are in place, leading to development of individuals who are not only successful for themselves but who also contribute positively to society, at large.

In essence, PYD is a forward-thinking, holistic approach that aligns with modern understandings of adolescent psychology and education. It suggests that when young people are given the tools to succeed and are supported in their personal development, they not only thrive individually but also contribute to the creation of a more just, productive, and compassionate society. This body of knowledge continues to grow, offering invaluable insights for educators, practitioners, policymakers, and all those committed to the well-being and future of young people.

Activity 1.2: Parents' Role in Nurturing (Time: 45 minutes)

Objectives. The objective of this activity is to let parents reflect on their role and how they can support their children to grow into healthy adults.

Resources.

- Music player, phone, or anything from which music can be played
- A bowl
- Chits having the following words written on them (add or subtract words as needed)
 - Leader
 - Empathetic
 - Honest
 - Responsible
 - Respectful
 - Caring

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Ask the participants to sit in a circle.
2. Tell them that music will be played and a bowl containing chits with certain attributes written on them will be passed around. When the music stops, the person holding the bowl will pick up a chit and say how they will support their child in acquiring that attribute.
3. Give them the bowl and ask them to pass it around until the music stops (after 30 seconds).
Play the music using the music player
4. The participant having the bowl when the music stops will take out one chit.
5. Ask that participant to read out the attribute written on the chit and say how they can support their child in order to instill that quality in them.
6. Do the rounds till all the chits in the bowl are finished. Ensure that all participants get a chance. If the bowl stops in the hand of a person who has already spoken, ask the next one, or the one after, who has not had the chance to speak, to take a chit and respond.
7. After this activity ask the participants the things they should be providing to their children (put the suggestions on the board/flip chart, supplementing as needed). Possible examples could be

- Shelter, clothes, personal hygiene items, etc.
 - Food (provision, cooking)
 - Taking care of their health – immunizations, visits to the clinic, providing comfort when ill, etc.
 - Reading to them when they are young, as this would instill the love for reading in them as they grow older
 - Singing with them
 - Offering namaz/prayers with them
 - Taking them to religious activities, such as majalis, etc.
 - School fees, lunch money
 - Teaching manners, responsibilities – setting rules, discipline.
 - Teaching and modeling life skills
 - Taking time out for outings, sports, board games, etc.
 - Providing encouragement
 - Helping with school work
 - Arranging extra lessons – tuition fees
 - Being there for them when needed
 - Addressing their psycho-social needs (need for appreciation, belongingness, love, etc.)
 - Maintaining their self-esteem Encouraging participation in extra-curricular activities: drawing, painting, music, sports, etc.
 - Vacations, trips around the country, visits to grandparents, aunts, uncles, going to picnic spots, etc.
8. After the discussion, ask them about the top five most important things from the list. (The answers can vary; consensus is not the objective; but parents must understand what things are important in their culture and family while raising their child).

9. Look back at the list again. Discuss the following questions with the participants:
- Were there any gender-based roles and why?
 - Where are these biases coming from?
 - Are these cultural/societal?
 - Which of these investments are usually made by fathers? And which ones are made by mothers? (You can put M or F beside the items, or both M and F).
 - Why is this so? Are there fathers who do things that mothers usually do? And vice-versa?
 - Can a father do everything that a mother can do? Can a mother do everything that a father can do?

Discuss and record the key points.

10. Next, tell the participants that parental responsibilities for children are different from the responsibilities that children have; many parents believe children owe them obedience and respect, without them earning it. Then, discuss the following questions with them. Make sure the discussion includes not only material payoffs down the road (taking care of parents), but also emotional/psychological benefits—pride, closer relationships, gratitude, etc.

- Are there payoffs for parents (for fathers, for mothers) in making these investments?

What are they?

- Do children OWE parents? Do parents OWE children? Why or why not?
- What would parent like to see from their investments in their children?
- How can parents “earn” better payoffs from their children?

Learning outcomes. Summarize the key points that emerged, and discuss whether these are short or long term investments.

Notes for facilitators regarding follow-up actions by parents.

- The choices made by parents are a crucial and primary influence on how children develop and what their future achievements will be.
- Parents choose the sort of nurturing, monitoring, disciplinary environment in which their children are raised.
- Investment of parents in themselves is also an investment, as it contributes towards their own personal growth, in addition to the growth of their family or extended family.

4. Some investments show results right away; others may take a long time.
5. Positive and regular investments in children, including interactions with them, also benefit parents.
6. Create a supportive environment, where adolescents feel comfortable expressing their feelings, concerns, and experiences.
7. Listen attentively to the adolescents' thoughts and emotions, without judgment. Allow them to feel heard and understood.
8. Show empathy towards the adolescents' struggles and challenges; validate their emotions, and provide reassurance.
9. Establish clear and consistent boundaries to provide structure and guidance, while respecting the adolescents' need for independence.
10. Recognize and praise the adolescents' strengths, efforts, and achievements, to boost their self-esteem and confidence.
11. Allow adolescents to make age-appropriate decisions and to take on responsibilities, to foster their autonomy and self-confidence.
12. Offer guidance and support in navigating social relationships, peer pressure, and decision-making, while also being a source of advice and wisdom.
13. Model healthy behaviors, coping mechanisms, and communication skills, which adolescents can emulate as they navigate their own psychosocial challenges.
14. Continue to promote their spiritual development by praying together and attending and performing religious activities together.
15. Promote cultivation of healthy and meaningful relationships – particularly within the family and friends – that inspire trust, security, and empathy.
16. Recognize when additional support is necessary and seek help from mental health professionals or counselors to address more complex psychosocial issues.

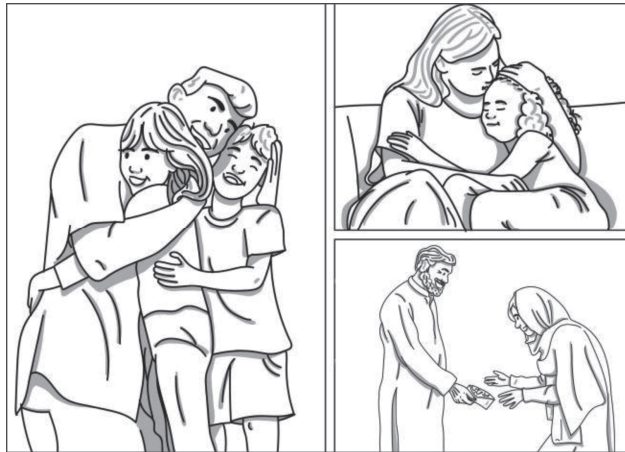
At the end, tell each participant to recall one thing from the session that they believe to be an “AHAAA” moment; something they intend to incorporate immediately. Tell them to note it down and do it.

Parenting Styles

Every parent has a different approach regarding how to interact with and guide their children. A child's morals, principles, and conduct are generally established through this parenting bond. There are four common parenting styles: Authoritarian, Authoritative, Permissive, and Uninvolved. Every style has a unique approach with regard to how parents raise their children. Generally, each parent follows one of these styles; however, they may sometimes have some characteristics from another style. Parenting style can also be dependent on situations. As a child grows older, other factors may affect their style, which can further shape their conduct or, possibly, change it entirely.

Authoritarian parenting.

Parents following this style tend to lay strict rules that the child has to obey. There is little or no room for negotiations with the child, and the rules are not usually explained. The parents expect their children to uphold the set standards; there is no room for errors. Mistakes usually lead to punishment. Authoritarian parents are normally less nurturing and have high expectations, with limited flexibility. Children that grow up with authoritarian parents will usually be the best-



behaved ones in the room, because of the fear of the consequences of misbehaving. They have poor self-esteem, which reinforces their inability to make decisions. Strict parental rules and punishments often influence the child and make them rebel against authority figures as they grow older.

Authoritative Parenting.

This type of parent normally develops a close, nurturing relationship with their children. They provide clear guidelines for expectations and explain their reasons for disciplinary actions. Disciplinary action is such that it supports, instead of it being a punishment. Children are encouraged to verbalize their goals and expectations. In general, this parenting style leads to the healthiest outcomes for children; however, it requires a lot of patience and effort from both parties. Authoritative parenting results in children who are confident, responsible, and able to self-regulate. They can manage their negative emotions more effectively, which leads to better social outcomes and emotional health. Since these parents encourage independence, their children learn to accomplish their own goals with higher self-esteem and with high academic achievement and school performance.

Permissive Parenting.

Permissive parents tend to be warm, nurturing and usually have minimum or no expectations. They impose limited rules on their children and have open communication with them and allow the children to figure things out for themselves. They rarely discipline their children, behaving more like friends than parents.

Children having such parents have a lot of freedom, as they decide their bedtime, if or when to do their homework, and how much screen time to have with the computer and television. Freedom to this extent can lead to many negative habits, due to lack of guidance on moderation. Overall, children of permissive parents usually have some self-esteem and reasonable social skills. However, they can be impulsive, demanding, selfish, and lack self-regulation.

Uninvolved Parenting.

Children, whose parents have this parenting style, are given a lot of freedom and parents normally stay out of their way. They fulfil the basic needs of their child while generally remaining detached from their life. Uninvolved parents do not have any disciplining style, and minimum communication with their child. They tend to offer the lowest possible nurturing and have either few or no expectations from their children.

The children of uninvolved parents are usually resilient and may even be more self-sufficient than children with other types of upbringings. However, these skills are developed out of necessity. Additionally, they might have trouble controlling their emotions, have less effective coping strategies, may have academic challenges, and difficulty in maintaining or nurturing social relationships.

Individuals display a mixture of different characteristics in different situations, with different people. Their personalities (the way we are most often) interact with their environment, so at any point in time, they are a product of their personalities and their perceptions. Understanding their own behavior style, as well as the behavior style of their children, can help them in better communicating with their children and in appreciating their actions and behaviors, their personalities.

Behavior Styles of Youth.

Behavior Styles is a section that focuses on the four behavior styles that human beings usually have. Although they can adapt their behaviors to different settings, individuals are predisposed to a

predominant style that makes them who they are. Helping parents discover their personal behavior style, as well as their children's style, can be a significant factor in improving communication between them.

The Behavioral Style Model. There are four distinct behavioral styles. While individuals can use all four of them, they tend to use one or two most frequently. The four styles are: DISC:

1. Dominance
2. Influence
3. Steadiness
4. Conscientious (Compliance, Cautiousness)

This behavioral style model is frequently referred to as DISC, because of the first letter of each style. These behavior styles are further elaborated as:

1. Dominance. Youth with a "D" style enjoy challenges and achieving results quickly. They do not wait for authority; they take control and are interested in the big picture, not details.

2. Influence. Youth demonstrating the "I" style is often thought of as "People-People". They prefer to be around others and tend to be very enthusiastic and entertaining. They enjoy contacting people, making a favourable impression, speaking articulately, creating a motivational environment, and participating in groups.

3. Steadiness Those demonstrating the "S" Style take a much more deliberate approach and do not like frequent change. They are patient and loyal. They have a real desire to be of service and help to others. They are also very good at calming people when they get upset, or during a conflict.

4. Conscientious: Individuals with the "C" style of behavior tends to focus on details. In fact, they pick up the tiniest, most minute items that others miss and keep the non-detailed people out of trouble.

Activity 1.3: Parenting Can Differ with Each Child (15-20 minutes)

Objectives. This activity will introduce participants to different personality styles and the fact that every child is different. The objective of this activity is to explain to parents that not every child is the same and that their needs are different.

Resources.

- Flip chart and markers
- Paper

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Tell the participants that people have different ways in which they behave and, most often, they have their own unique style. These are referred to as behavior styles.
2. Invite parents to focus for a few minutes on one or two of their children and identify the ways in which they behave most of the time; for example, demanding, ambitious, enthusiastic, warm, calm, stable, careful, diplomatic, neat, etc.; invite them to think of other words that describe their behavior.
3. Have four charts with the following phrases:
 - Relates to control, power, and assertiveness
 - Relates to social situations and communication
 - Relates to patience, persistence, and thoughtfulness
 - Relates to structure and organization

Have a general discussion on the statements and see if they can identify where the words that they chose to describe their children fit.

Learning outcomes. At the end of the activity, explain that the stated words describe their child's characteristics and that every child is different. Every child behaves differently; some are introverts, while some are extroverts; some are adventurous and sporty, while others prefer indoor games. Never compare and do not expect the same from every child.

Notes for facilitators regarding follow-up actions by parents.

How to deal with children having the *D* style. Verbalize the desired result, and provide them with space to deliver it, independently. Refrain from micro-managing them, or providing long, detailed explanations.

How to deal with children having the *I* style. Approach them in a personable, relaxed, upbeat manner. Do not shower them with details or be too serious. Use humor. Let them know you appreciate their efforts and value them. Recognize their accomplishments.

How to deal with children having the *S* style. Approach them in a warm, but deliberate manner. Explain step-by-step the best way to get things done. Let them know that they can count on you. Follow-up when you say you will. Limit changes in the midst of a project, chore, unless absolutely required to do so. Give them time to adjust to change. Practice mutual respect of time and commitment.

How to deal with children having the *C* style

Provide children with the rules and details pertaining to the task on hand. Do not be vague in response to their questions and back it up with facts. Avoid surprises and be patient.

Communication Skills

Communication in families is characterized by mutual respect and the ability to freely exchange feelings and ideas. Parents who understand their teenagers' need for a reasonable measure of independence and individuality encourage their child's growth and achievements. However, parents need to be aware that effective communication has to do with more than simply sharing information and exchanging ideas. It involves:



- a. Imparting of thoughts, opinions, and information through speech, writing, or signs
- b. Developing skills to share information and understanding verbal and non-verbal meanings
- c. Serving as a medium for bonding and support

Children learn how to communicate by watching their parents. If parents communicate openly and effectively, chances are that their children will also do so. Good communication skills will benefit children throughout their lives. Hence, parents must understand that:

- Communication between parents and children that is ineffective or negative can lead to children believing that they are unimportant, unheard, or misunderstood. Such children may also come to see their parents as unhelpful and untrustworthy.
- Parents who communicate effectively with their children are more likely to have children who are willing to do what they are told. Such children know what to expect from their parents, and once children know what is expected of them, they are more likely to live up to those expectations. They are also more likely to feel secure about their position in the family and are thus more likely to be cooperative. Parents who engage in an open conversation and respect mutual expectations, with no judgement, are more likely to raise confident law-abiding citizens.
- Active listening is the key to effective communication and is an important skill that parents must have. It is a specific form of communication that lets another person know that you

are “with them,” aware of what they are saying, accepting their perspective, and appreciative of their situation.

By listening to them, you are communicating that they are worthy of your attention. By hearing attentively about their distress, you are demonstrating that their view of the world has merit. By allowing them time to decide their course of action, you are indicating your trust in their ability to solve problems.

<u>What to DO</u>	<u>What to SAY</u>
Listen	I feel that now you want to be listened
Appreciate	I am so proud of you!
Emotions	I Love You, I am angry with you!!
Respect	If that’s what you have decided, let me know how can I help you?
Trust	I know you will be responsible, I trust you!

Activity 1.4: Effective Communication (10 minutes)

Objectives. The purpose of this activity is to highlight the importance of effective communication. Adolescents receive information from various sources, so it's crucial for parents to maintain healthy communication with them to remain their primary source of information, and their first point of contact for confirming the information they receive.

Resources.

- Flipchart papers labeled “Effective Communication” and markers
- Blank papers
- Masks

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Think of a brief phrase for the first activity, and write it on a piece of paper.
2. Write the terms and definition related to “Effective Communication” on one flipchart page, “Active Listening” on another flipchart page, and phrases for communication, “tips”, on yet another page.
3. Give masks to all the participants and ask them to wear these.
4. Tell the participants that you have a phrase written on this piece of paper (hold up the folded paper with the phrase written on it), which you will whisper in the ear of the first participant in the line.
5. This participant will whisper it as quietly as possible in her neighbor’s ear (keeping the mask on). The neighbor will then pass on the message s/he heard to the next participant, and so on, until we come to the end of the line. Then the participant at the end of the line will share the message s/he received.
6. When the last participant has shared the phrase with the group, unfold the paper and read it.
7. Point out the difference, and say that sometimes when we try to communicate, we lose important information along the way.
8. Tell the participants that, at times, when we tell our children something or they hear things from some other source they do not hear it the way it is said. It is, therefore, important that parents talk to their children in a clear manner and ensure that the children have clearly understood what has been said. Explain to the participants that when there is good communication, misunderstandings can be avoided, and when problems arise, they can be solved more easily.

Learning outcomes: After this activity parents will be able to see what causes gaps in communication. They will have a better understanding of communicating effectively with their children.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Provide the following tips to the parents:

Provide quality time.

1. Being there for your child is very important. Being only physically present is not sufficient; listening partially while busy with some other work is not enough. Make sure that you are mentally and physically present for your child when they are in need.
2. Set a routine of bedtime, lunchtime, or walk time where you and child can spend quality time.
3. Initiate the conversation so that the child knows you are interested in their lives.
4. Plan an activity once a week with your child, like have lunch outside, try a sport, do gardening, visit someone, etc., with them. Try not to schedule work related things during that time.

Let your child/children know you're listening.

- When your children are talking about concerns, stop whatever you are doing and listen.
- Express interest in what they are saying without being intrusive.
- Listen to their point of view, even if it is difficult to comprehend.
- Let them complete their point before you respond.
- Repeat what you heard them say to ensure that you have understood them correctly.

Pay attention.

- Pay attention to what your child is saying.
- Stop whatever you are doing and give them your full attention.
- If you are busy, tell your child: "I'm busy now, can we talk later?", unless it is an urgent matter or something that is time specific. In which case, find the time to listen to your child

Maintain eye contact.

- Eye contact improves communication.
- Reduce the physical distance between you and your child.
- Bend down or sit on the floor to be at an eye-to- eye level with your child.

Hear the child when they are speaking.

- Do not interrupt your child.
- Praise them when they finish speaking.

Be empathetic towards them.

- Soften strong reactions; children will tune you out or be defensive, if you appear to be angry.
- Express your opinion without putting down theirs; acknowledge that it is okay to disagree.
- Resist arguing about who is right. Instead say, “I know you disagree with me, but this is what I think.”

This video shall be played during or after the session:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VWNH99t9Ijg>